

# Puzzles in pronominal structure from Nord-Jæren

Erlend Øyvindssønn Ravnanger, Pritty Patel-Grosz,  
Patrick Georg Grosz

*This paper focuses on pronouns in the Norwegian dialects spoken in the Nord-Jæren region, a geographic area in Rogaland county on the Norwegian West Coast. We present a data set focusing on three variants of the 3rd person feminine singular object pronoun (“her”): hu, ’na and henna. We raise the question how these three variants fit into pronominal typologies such as Cardinaletti & Starke’s (1996, 1999) classification of pronouns as clitic, weak and strong. We present a survey where participants (n=822) were asked to choose which of the three pronouns fits best in a given sentence. The survey results indicate that ’na is the unmarked form, whereas hu and henna are preferred in a subset of contexts, such as the topic position and the complement position of a copula verb. The overall data are indicative of a markedness hierarchy (from least marked to most marked): ’na < hu < henna. Within this markedness hierarchy, both hu and henna pattern as strong pronouns in the sense of Cardinaletti & Starke (1996, 1999), whereas ’na qualifies as a weak pronoun. These generalizations lay the groundwork for further exploration into the morphosyntactic properties of the Nord-Jæren dialects, which bears on the question of how pronominal systems are organized cross-linguistically, particularly whether languages can have more than one pronominal paradigm that classifies as strong.*

# 1. The Phenomenon

This paper investigates dialectal variation of the 3<sup>rd</sup> person feminine object pronoun ( $\approx$  English “her”) in the Norwegian dialects of Stavanger, and, more generally, Nord-Jæren, which includes the municipalities Stavanger, Sandnes, Sola and Randaberg.<sup>1</sup> Taking data from the Stavanger dialect as our point of departure, the Nordic Dialect Corpus<sup>2</sup> (Johannessen et al. 2009) has a total of 7 tokens of feminine accusative pronouns in Stavanger, of which three recordings are from the same speaker (born in 1939 and recorded in 2008), illustrated in (1)-(3). These examples exhibit a three-way distinction: the clitic *'na* “her” in (1) appears to compete with two alternatives, *hu* “her” in (2) (identical to the subject form; also pronounced *u*) and *henna* “her” in (3), also pronounced *hennar*, *hennår* or *henne*.<sup>3</sup>

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1 In line with native speaker intuitions from this dialectal area, we assume that the Nord-Jæren dialects exhibit a homogenous pattern with regards to pronominal grammar, so we will look at Nord-Jæren dialects collectively, rather than looking at the more local dialects, such as the Stavanger dialect (*Stavangersk*) or the Sandnes dialect (*Gaugamål*).

2 <http://www.tekstlab.uio.no/nota/scandiasyn/>

3 Two remarks are in order: Since *hu* also has a clitic *'u* variant, it may be appropriate to speak of a four-way distinction rather than a three-way distinction. Initial intuitions that we collected suggest that *'na* and *henna* are perceived as distinct pronouns, whereas *hu* and *'u* are perceived to be pronunciation variants. There are many aspects of the pronominal paradigms that we need to gloss over for present purposes, such as a complete exploration of the role of stress and other phonological factors in the distribution of the pronoun forms. While it can be assumed that *'na* historically originated as an unstressed variant of *henna*, a binary distinction between unstressed and stressed pronouns cannot account for a three-way distinction; at the same time, we expect to find a correlation such that more reduced pronominal forms are unstressed whereas their full counterparts are stressed. We also gloss over smaller phonetic differences such as factors that may govern the choice between *henna*, *hennar*, *hennår*, and *henne*; the forms ending in *-r* are mentioned both in Berntsen & Larsen (1925) and Svendsen (1931).

- (1) Stavanger (NDC position 2474030)  
*... n ska hennte **na***  
 one will pick.up her  
 “Someone will pick her up.”
- (2) Stavanger (NDC position 2471014)  
*... har du værrt møje samen me **hu**?*  
 have you been much together with her  
 “Have you been much together with her?”
- (3) Stavanger (NDC position 2468125)  
*... egg sæie te **hennår** ...*  
 I say to her  
 “I say to her.”

The time frame (year of birth and recording) associated with the speaker whose utterances are given in (1)-(3) indicates that the three-way variation in how the 3<sup>rd</sup> person feminine object pronoun is realized is not a recent phenomenon. Consultants who were born in later decades express the intuition that all three variants are possible in their own dialect as well.

The four forms of the object pronoun in the Nord-Jæren dialects (including the reduced ‘*u* for completeness’ sake) resemble the forms found in other Norwegian dialects, but do not exhibit a one-to-one mapping. To our knowledge, pronominal systems in Norwegian dialects have not received much attention in the theoretical literature. Among the notable exceptions is Åfarli & Fjøsne (2012:78), who discuss the Halså dialect, spoken in Møre og Romsdal county. The Halså dialect has cognates of the four pronominal forms that we find in Nord-Jæren; however, it makes a two-way distinction between syncretic nominative/accusative forms and a separate dative form; to our knowledge, there is no indication that the Stavanger/Nord-Jæren dialect has preserved dative case on pronouns (compare Garbacz 2014). The two patterns are contrasted in Table 1 (quoting the Halså pattern from Åfarli & Fjøsne 2012:78).

|     | <b>Nord-Jæren<br/>(Stavanger dialect)</b> | <b>Halsa</b> |
|-----|-------------------------------------------|--------------|
| nom | hu / 'u                                   | ho / 'o      |
| acc | hu / 'u / henna / 'na                     | ho / 'o      |
| dat | —                                         | hænna / 'na  |

*Table 1: feminine pronouns in Stavanger and Halsa dialect*

Setting aside other dialects (including the Halsa dialect), our aim is to determine how the three-way distinction in Nord-Jæren dialects fits into pronominal markedness hierarchies such as the one proposed by Cardinaletti & Starke (1996, 1999), which we introduce in Section 2.

## 2. Theoretical background

Many languages exhibit more than one paradigm of pronouns, which appear synonymous, but differ in their distribution. An early discussion of the phenomenon, widely considered a “classic”, is Montalbetti’s (1984) discussion of null and overt pronouns in the Romance languages. Amongst other things, Montalbetti observes that only null pronouns can be bound by a quantifier in Spanish, whereas overt pronouns cannot. This is illustrated in (4)a (where the overt pronoun must refer to a specific individual) vs. (4)b (where the null pronoun can be bound by the quantifier).

- (4) Spanish (Montalbetti 1984:26; stylistically adapted)
- a. *Nadie<sub>i</sub> cree que él<sub>k/\*i</sub> es inteligente*  
nobody believes that he is intelligent
  - b. *Nadie<sub>i</sub> cree que pro<sub>k/i</sub> es inteligente*  
nobody believes that he is intelligent  
“Nobody believes that he is intelligent.”

In recent years, many scholars have proposed that competing pronominal paradigms in a given language differ in the internal structure of the pronouns, for example Cardinaletti & Starke (1999), Wiltschko (1998), Patel-Grosz & Grosz (2017), and Patel-Grosz (2020). As a concrete example, Wiltschko and Patel-Grosz & Grosz argue that German personal pronouns (*er/sie/es*) are structurally less complex than demonstrative pronouns (*der/die/das*). Relatedly, Cardinaletti & Starke propose a tripartition of pronouns into strong,

weak and clitic pronouns; different languages instantiate the pronominal typology in different ways, e.g., a language may only differentiate between strong and weak pronouns, and not have clitics. At the same time, some languages instantiate all three types of pronouns: an illustration of a language with all three classes is Slovak, which has strong pronouns (*jemu* ‘he.dat/it.dat’), weak pronouns (*ono* ‘it.nom’) and clitic pronouns (*mu* ‘he.dat/it.dat’) (Cardinaletti & Starke 1999:166).

While Cardinaletti & Starke (1999) introduce a strong-weak-clitic tripartition, Patel-Grosz & Grosz (2017) and Patel-Grosz (2020) argue that many languages draw a strong-weak distinction that is relativized to the language: non-clitic pronouns may qualify as *strong* in a language that also has clitics (or null pronouns), while qualifying as *weak* in a language without clitics that uses demonstrative pronouns. To illustrate this proposal, compare (4) to (5) (see Wiltschko 1998:144). The contrast between Spanish overt pronouns (which cannot be bound) and null pronouns (which can be bound) is mirrored by the contrast between German demonstrative pronouns and personal pronouns. Patel-Grosz & Grosz (2017) and Patel-Grosz (2020) take this to indicate that the *weak-strong* distinction is relative to a given language, i.e., personal pronouns qualify as strong in Spanish, (6)a, and weak in German, (6)b.

(5) German (personal knowledge)

- a. *Kein Mann<sub>i</sub> glaubt, dass der<sub>k/\*i</sub> intelligent ist*  
no man believes that DEM intelligent is
- b. *Kein Mann<sub>i</sub> glaubt, dass er<sub>k/i</sub> intelligent ist*  
no man believes that he intelligent is  
“No man believes that he is intelligent.”

(6) Strength scale

- a. *null vs. overt pronoun languages (e.g. Spanish)*  
null pronoun < personal pronoun (< demonstrative pronoun)  
**weak**                      **strong**
- b. *personal vs. demonstrative pronoun languages (e.g. German)*  
(null pronoun <) personal pronoun < demonstrative pronoun  
**weak**                      **strong**

Studies on pronominal typology (including the present text) generally

focus on case studies (e.g., see Wiltschko 1998 for a study of pronouns in German, and Cardinaletti & Starke 1999 and Patel-Grosz & Grosz 2017 for two studies that cover a set of languages). A predictive theory of *possible* pronominal typologies is still missing: are there human languages with pronominal paradigms that do not follow structural asymmetries of the proposed type, and, if so, how is pronominal choice governed in these languages?

Our present goal is to underscore the necessity of looking at microvariation as part of developing such a predictive typology. While many previous studies focus on standard languages, research on dialectal variation within a given language still remains limited. In what follows, we argue that the Norwegian dialects of Nord-Jæren reveal a pattern where two strong 3<sup>rd</sup> person feminine object pronouns are in competition with each other: *hu*, which exhibits nominative-accusative syncretism, and *henna*, which has a distinct accusative form. This observation goes against the central hypothesis of Cardinaletti & Starke (1999:167) that there is no language with two paradigms of strong pronouns; this hypothesis has rarely been questioned, with notable exceptions in Cetnarowska (2004) and Jung & Migdalski (2022). Future research needs to decide whether the Nord-Jæren system is a stable system, or a system that is currently undergoing change, e.g., towards the disappearance of *henna* in favor of *hu*. Notably, Berntsen & Larsen (1925) do not mention *hu* in object position, which suggests that the nominative-accusative syncretism of *hu* has emerged more recently, whereas the original system only had a two-way distinction between the strong *henna* and its weak counterpart *'na*.

### 3. Methodology

We report on an anonymous web-based survey (Ravnanger 2023) with 14 items; the survey's original objective was to explore if the choice of *hu* vs. *'na* was conditioned by the phonological context;<sup>4</sup> accordingly, examples were created on the basis of phonological criteria (e.g., whether the preceding sound was a consonant or vowel) and intuitive naturalness. However, the items were not manipulated to control for stress and contrastive readings as possible factors in

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4 One original hypothesis was that *hu* would be preferred after consonants and *'na* after vowels. The results do not show evidence for such phonological conditioning.

pronominal choice.

Items were presented to participants in written form as illustrated in (7).<sup>5</sup> Participants carried out a forced-choice task, where they were asked if *hu*, *henna/-e* or *na* was the most natural pronoun to fill in the gap in the example sentence.<sup>6</sup> As a fourth option, participants could choose *alle er like korrekte* “all are equally correct”.

- (7) **Item 1** (translation: “Have you picked her up?”)  
«Har du henta \_\_\_\_\_»  
☐hu   ☐henna/-e   ☐na   ☐alle er like korrekte

The survey link was circulated among personal acquaintances and posted in the Facebook group *Stavanger før i tidå*; participants were asked if they spoke a dialect from the Nord-Jæren region; but, upon answering “yes”, they were not asked to specify their Nord-Jæren dialect more closely.

## 4. Survey results

### 4.1. Number of participants

A total number of 849 participants completed the survey, of whom 823 indicated that they spoke a dialect from Nord-Jæren. One participant did not respond to any of our items, yielding a total number of  $n=822$  participants who provided answers. Participants could skip items; the minimum number of submissions per item was 789 (for item 3 of the survey, which is given in (23)); the maximum number of submissions was 821 (for five of the items).

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- 5 Naturally, the fact that materials were presented in written form limits the range of factors that could be controlled for, which may be reflected in the results, as discussed in Sections 4 and 5. For future follow-up studies, a presentation in auditory form would be recommended, which would allow the experimenters to control for stress and contrastive readings, among other relevant factors.
- 6 The clitic *'u* was not tested in this survey. The inclusion of *henna* and *henne* in the form of *henna/-e* was intended to cover interspeaker variation in how this pronominal form is pronounced.

## 4.2. Patterns of interspeaker variation

We take our point of departure from speakers with the type of grammar illustrated in (1)-(3), who have all three variants of the 3<sup>rd</sup> person singular feminine pronoun in their pronominal system. An initial question is whether our study participants match this description.

An initial screening shows that 55 of our 822 participants (6.69%) chose one and the same pronoun in all items for which they provided an answer (31 participants always chose *hu*, 21 *henna/-e*, and 3 *'na*). By contrast, 384 of our 822 participants (46.72%) chose two pronouns across the items for which they provided an answer (316 participants chose *hu* or *'na*, 45 participants chose *henna/-e* or *'na*, and 23 participants chose *henna/-e* or *hu*); out of the 384 participants who chose two pronouns, 55 also chose the answer *Alle er like korrekte* “all are equally correct” at least once. Most relevant for our aims, 378 participants (45.99%) chose each of the three pronouns at least once. In addition, there was 1 participant who always chose the option *Alle er like korrekte*, 1 participant who chose a mix of *henna/-e* and *Alle er like korrekte*, and 3 participants who chose a mix of *hu* and *Alle er like korrekte*. These 5 participants are excluded from further discussion (and thus not included in (8) below).

To summarize, our data are compatible with the assumption that there are seven different grammars (G1-G7) across our participants, as illustrated in (8). However, two options are more frequently represented than the others: G4 in (8)d represents participants ( $n=316$ ) who chose *hu* and *'na* but never chose *henna* (though 50 of them also chose the option *Alle er like korrekte* at least once); and G7 in (8)g represents participants ( $n=378$ ) who chose each of the three pronouns at least once. Together, G4 and G7 make up 84.43% of our study participants, and G7 (the largest group of participants) is equivalent to the grammar illustrated in (1)-(3).

### (8) Possible grammars for Nord-Jæren pronouns

- a. G1 (only *hu*):  $n=31$  (3.8%)
- b. G2 (only *henna*):  $n=21$  (2.6%)
- c. G3 (only *'na*):  $n=3$  (0.4%)
- d. G4 (*hu* and *'na*):  $n=316$  (38.4%)
- e. G5 (*henna* and *'na*):  $n=45$  (5.5%)
- f. G6 (*henna* and *hu*):  $n=23$  (2.8%)

g. G7 (*hu*, *'na* and *henna*):  $n=378$  (46.0%)

Within the group of participants who chose each pronoun at least once (G7;  $n=378$ ), there are different sub-groupings as to the frequency with which they chose the respective pronouns. These sub-groupings are summarized in (9), where the subgroups are sorted by frequency in descending order. Here, “>” stands for “more frequently chosen than”, and “=” stands for “chosen exactly as often as”. Percentages in (9) are calculated out of  $n=378$ .

(9) Different preferences in grammars with three pronouns (G7)

- a. *'na* > *hu* > *henna*:  $n=127$  (33.6%)
- b. *'na* > *henna* > *hu*:  $n=77$  (20.4%)
- c. *hu* > *'na* > *henna*:  $n=59$  (15.6%)
- d. *'na* > {*henna*=*hu*}:  $n=41$  (10.8%)
- e. {*hu*=*'na*} > *henna*:  $n=21$  (5.6%)
- f. *henna* > *'na* > *hu*:  $n=16$  (4.2%)
- g. *hu* > {*henna*=*'na*}:  $n=10$  (2.6%)
- h. {*henna*=*'na*} > *hu*:  $n=7$  (1.9%)
- i. *henna* > {*'na*=*hu*}:  $n=7$  (1.9%)
- j. *hu* > *henna* > *'na*:  $n=6$  (1.6%)
- k. {*henna*=*hu*} > *'na*:  $n=4$  (1.1%)
- l. *henna* = *hu* = *'na*:  $n=2$  (<1%)
- m. *henna* > *hu* > *'na*:  $n=1$  (<1%)

We conclude that almost half (46.0%) of all study participants ( $n=378$ ) have a grammar that allows for all three pronouns, with varying preferences for the different pronouns, as illustrated in (9). In what follows, we analyze the answers participants provided for each of the 14 stimuli; in doing so, we limit our sample to the 378 participants in (9), rather than analyzing the full sample of 822 participants. This step is warranted by the fact that we are specifically interested in the grammar of Nord-Jæren speakers who accept all three 3<sup>rd</sup> person singular feminine pronouns in object position (i.e., the G7-speakers).

### 4.3. Clitic *'na* as the default choice

Half of the 14 examples had a strong endorsement (>60%) for *'na* across all submissions. These 7 examples are given in (10)-(16); our

presentation of the example includes the percentage with which each pronoun was chosen (in superscripts after the pronoun), and the total number of submissions ( $n$ ) per item (in parentheses at the end of the example) – with a possible maximum value of  $n=378$ . The answer option *alle er like korrekte* “all are equally correct” is omitted from our examples for ease of exposition; this option was not endorsed by a sizeable percentage for any of the items; the highest percentage of endorsement for “all are equally correct” occurred in the response to (19) below, where 3.5% of participants (13 of 375) chose this option.<sup>7</sup> Since our examples do not include the percentage for the answer option “all are equally correct”, the percentages do not add up to 100%; e.g., percentages in (10) add up to 97.8%, since “all are equally correct” was chosen by 2.2% of participants.

(10) *Har du henta {na<sup>85.9%</sup> / hu<sup>7.7%</sup> / henna<sup>4.2%</sup>}?* ( $n=377$ )  
 have you picked.up her  
 “Have you picked her up?”

(11) *Eg møtte {na<sup>63.5%</sup> / hu<sup>26.5%</sup> / henna<sup>6.6%</sup>}. (n=378)*  
 I met her  
 “I met her.”

(12) *Eg såg {na<sup>81.0%</sup> / hu<sup>14.3%</sup> / henna<sup>3.2%</sup>}. (n=378)*  
 I saw her  
 “I saw her.”

(13) *Eg ser {na<sup>69.5%</sup> / hu<sup>23.9%</sup> / henna<sup>4.5%</sup>}. (n=377)*  
 I see her  
 “I am seeing her.”

(14) *Stopp {na<sup>76.6%</sup> / hu<sup>13.0%</sup> / henna<sup>8.2%</sup>}!* ( $n=376$ )  
 stop her  
 “Stop her!”

(15) *Lucy e den nye katten min.*  
 Lucy is the new cat.DEF my  
*Eg har kjøpt {na<sup>65.3%</sup> / hu<sup>25.4%</sup> / henna<sup>7.4%</sup>}. (n=378)*  
 I have bought her

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<sup>7</sup> To simplify, the illustrations only include *henna*, and not its variants; in the study itself, the presented option was *henna/-e*, as shown in (7).

“Lucy is my new cat. I have bought her.”

- (16) *Eg sølte på* {*na*<sup>68.4%</sup> / *hu*<sup>16.6%</sup> / *henna*<sup>11.8%</sup>}. (n=374)  
I spilled on her  
“I spilled on her.”

In addition to the overarching preference for *'na*, we observe that a non-negligible share of participants prefer *hu* in (10)-(16); for example, 26.5% chose *hu* as their preferred option in (11) (amounting to 100 of 378 participants). The stimuli did not control for information structural aspects such as focus, so we cannot determine from the surveyed examples whether information structure or stress was a factor in participants' choice between *'na* and *hu*; this may be a factor in accounting for interspeaker fluctuation, as each participant would have imagined the pronunciation that would be most natural to them.

Three of the 14 surveyed examples present a more balanced pattern, where the number of *'na* responses is lower (<60%), while both the number of *hu* responses and the number of *henna* responses is higher, (17)-(19).

- (17) *Finn* {*na*<sup>59.0%</sup> / *hu*<sup>24.7%</sup> / *henna*<sup>13.6%</sup>}. (n=376)  
find her  
“Find her!”

- (18) *Eg e me* {*na*<sup>51.1%</sup> / *hu*<sup>27.5%</sup> / *henna*<sup>18.2%</sup>}. (n=374)  
I am with her  
“I am with her.”

- (19) *Eg går te* {*na*<sup>41.3%</sup> / *hu*<sup>28.3%</sup> / *henna*<sup>26.9%</sup>}. (n=375)  
I go to her  
“I am going to her.”

The patterns in (10)-(19) (which represent 10 of the 14 items that were tested) strongly argue that *'na* is the default option for speakers of the Nord-Jæren dialect; based on Cardinaletti & Starke (1999) and subsequent work, we infer that the clitic *'na* is structurally weaker than its competitors *hu* and *henna*; this is captured by the partial strength scale in (20).

#### (20) Partial strength scale

*'na* < {*hu* / *henna*}  
weak strong  
(where '<' stands for 'weaker than /structurally more minimal than')

Note that *'na* patterns like a *weak* pronoun in the spirit of Cardinaletti & Starke (1996, 1999), rather than how Cardinaletti & Starke define *clitic* pronouns in the narrow sense, since they take object clitics to be generally banned from the complement position of preposition phrases (Cardinaletti & Starke 1996:24).<sup>8</sup> Our survey includes several examples where *'na* occurs in this position: *på'na* 'at=her' in (16), *me'na* 'with=her' in (18) and *te'na* 'to=her' in (19).

While there is a clear preference for *'na* in sentences like (10)-(19), certain speakers show a preference for one of the other forms. We looked at interspeaker variation among the 378 participants who accept all three pronouns by reviewing the participants' individual submissions. In doing so, we found that 28 participants chose *hu* in six or more of the ten items in (10)-(19) (amounting to 7.4% of the total 378), and 10 participants chose *henna* in six or more of the items (2.6% of the total). In comparison, 261 participants (69%) chose *'na* as the preferred option in six or more of the items. This leaves 79 participants (20.9%) who did not exhibit a pronounced preference for any of the three pronouns.

### 4.4. Examples with a preference for *hu* or *henna* in object function

The survey contained four examples in which *'na* was dispreferred in favor of *hu* and *henna*, given in (21)-(24). In two of these examples, *'na* was strongly dispreferred, receiving only 1.6% endorsement in (21) (i.e., 6 of 375 participants), and 0.3% endorsement in (22) (which amounts to 1 of 378 participants). In both of these examples, *henna* was chosen more frequently than *'na*, whereas *hu* was the most frequently chosen variant.

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8 It is controversial whether all clitics are banned from such positions; an in-depth exploration of this issue is outside of the scope of this paper.

- (21) *Men {hu<sup>79.5%</sup> / henna<sup>18.7%</sup> / na<sup>1.6%</sup>} såg du jo! (n=375)*  
 but her saw you PRT  
 “But, her, you saw!”
- (22) *Viss eg va {hu<sup>56.3%</sup> / henna<sup>42.9%</sup> / na<sup>0.3%</sup>}, ville eg ... (n=378)*  
 if I were her would I  
 “If I were her, I would ...”

One remark is in place: while our study did not control for phonological conditioning factors such as stress associated with contrastive readings, example (21) is strongly suggestive of a contrastive reading ( $\approx$  “you saw her, and not somebody else”); we return to this point in Section 5.2.

Two examples where *na* was similarly dispreferred in favor of *hu* and *henna* are given in (23)-(24), though we observe that *henna* was the most frequently chosen variant in these two examples.

- (23) *Eg vil bli {henna<sup>55.2%</sup> / hu<sup>30.6%</sup> / na<sup>11.1%</sup>}. (n=359)*  
 I want become her  
 “I want to become her.”
- (24) *Eg spise hos {henna<sup>49.7%</sup> / hu<sup>27.4%</sup> / na<sup>20.2%</sup>}. (n=372)*  
 I eat at her  
 “I eat at her place.”

## 5. Discussion of the findings

### 5.1. Establishing a fully ordered strength scale

Our survey measured pronominal preference *across* participants. Prior to presenting an analysis of the individual items in Sections 4.3 and 4.4., we checked the extent to which pronoun choice is a reflection of interspeaker variation within the Nord-Jæren region, in Section 4.2. As outlined in (8), our findings are compatible with seven possible grammars present among speakers of Nord-Jæren dialects, of which two are most strongly supported: speakers who accept *hu* and *na*, but not *henna* (G4 in (8)d), and speakers who accept all three pronouns

(G7 in (8)g). We subsequently focused on the latter group.

A null hypothesis with regards to speakers of this group may hold that speakers choose between the three pronominal variants at random. A strong argument against such a view can be made on the basis of the observation that some examples exhibit a clear preference for *'na*, (25), others a clear preference for *hu*, (26), and others a clear preference for *henna*, (27). This variation in endorsement for the different pronominal forms indicates that participants follow implicit rules in selecting one of the three options.

(25) *Har du henta {na<sup>85.9%</sup> / hu<sup>7.7%</sup> / henna<sup>4.2%</sup>}?* (n=377)

have you picked.up her

“Have you picked her up?”

(26) *Men {hu<sup>79.5%</sup> / henna<sup>18.7%</sup> / na<sup>1.6%</sup>} såg du jo!* (n=375)

but her saw you PRT

“But, her, you saw!”

(27) *Eg vil bli {henna<sup>55.2%</sup> / hu<sup>30.6%</sup> / na<sup>11.1%</sup>}.* (n=359)

I want become her

“I want to become her.”

The fact that *'na* is the preferred pronoun in most contexts suggests that it is the structurally most minimal variant in terms of Cardinaletti & Starke (1999) and Patel-Grosz & Grosz (2017), who argue that pronouns with less structure must be chosen unless there are pragmatic factors at play that favor a pronoun with more structure.

Two hypotheses are plausible: either *'na* competes with {*hu*, *henna*} and the latter are in stylistically conditioned free variation; or the three variants are on a fully ordered strength scale. By the same logic that favors a classification of *'na* as the weakest pronoun, we may tentatively suggest that *hu* is structurally more minimal than *henna*, since *hu* is preferred over *henna* in 12 of 14 items. The *henna* variant only receives a higher endorsement percentage than *hu* in two of the items, given in (23) and (24), which makes it the most marked of the three variants. Accordingly, a fully ordered strength scale is presented in (28).

(28) Hypothesized (fully ordered) strength scale

*'na*      <      *hu*      <      *henna*  
weak                  strong                  strongest  
(where '<' stands for 'weaker than /structurally more minimal than')

Such a strength scale is also plausible due to the weight difference between the monosyllabic *hu* and the disyllabic *henna* (compare Wiltschko 1998 for similar argumentation). Note that example (26) strongly indicates that *hu* is a strong pronoun rather than a weak pronoun in the sense of Cardinaletti & Starke (1999), since weak object pronouns generally cannot be topicalized into the pre-verb-second position (Cardinaletti & Starke 1996:22,29; see Frey 2006 for discussion). As a consequence, Nord-Jæren dialects seem to have two strong pronouns, *hu* and *henna*.

## 5.2. Licensing strong pronouns: topicalization

The current data set does not reveal all of the factors that license a strong pronoun such as *hu* or *henna*. However, we can start exploring these factors by revisiting examples that exhibit a preference for the stronger pronouns.

The preference for *hu* in the pre-verb-second topic position, (29) (repeated from (21)), can be explained in terms of information structural properties, which may have a phonological effect; prominence positions such as the topicalized pre-verb-second position generally require stress and disallow weak pronouns (Cardinaletti & Starke 1996:22,29). This explains why the weak clitic *'na* cannot occur in the pre-verb-second position, and a strong pronoun must be chosen, which could either be *hu* or *henna* in (29).

- (29) *Men {hu<sup>79.5%</sup> / henna<sup>18.7%</sup> / na<sup>1.6%</sup>} såg du jo! (n=375)*  
but her saw you PRT  
“But, her, you saw!”

We may initially expect *henna* to be the most frequently chosen pronoun in (29), as it is intuitively the non-clitic variant of *'na*. The fact that *hu* is in fact most frequently chosen indicates that *hu* is less marked than *henna*, as hypothesized in (28). An alternative

explanation of (29) could be that this is a configuration where a non-nominative object case (accusative or dative) disappears under topicalization; under such a view, *hu* would in fact be nominative in (29). Such a pattern has previously been observed for *dative* case in the Romsdal dialect by Sandøy (2000:234) (see Åfarli & Fjøsne 2012:87 for discussion); however, it has not previously been observed for accusative case in Norwegian dialects, to our knowledge, making this a less likely interpretation of the data.

Example (29) is also a case where our data set includes a similar example, (30), which has the object pronoun in post-verbal position, and exhibits an overarching preference for *'na* rather than *hu*.

- (30) *Eg såg {na<sup>81.0%</sup> / hu<sup>14.3%</sup> / henna<sup>3.2%</sup>}. (n=378)*  
 I saw her  
 “I saw her.”

Examples (29)-(30) are the closest to a minimal pair in our data set; this allows us to provide a further snapshot of interspeaker variation, given in Table 2. A majority (n=240, 63.5%) of the 378 surveyed participants exhibit a preference for *'na* in (30) and *hu* in (29), but other patterns are attested as well, e.g., *'na* in (30), *henna* in (29).

| <i>Eg såg [pron].</i>   | <i>Men [pron] såg du jo!</i> | <i>n</i> | <i>perc.</i> |
|-------------------------|------------------------------|----------|--------------|
| na                      | hu                           | 240      | 63.5%        |
| na                      | henna                        | 57       | 15.1%        |
| hu                      | hu                           | 45       | 11.9%        |
| henna                   | hu                           | 10       | 2.6%         |
| hu                      | henna                        | 8        | 2.1%         |
| na                      | na                           | 5        | 1.3%         |
| all are equally correct | hu                           | 3        | <1%          |
| all are equally correct | henna                        | 3        | <1%          |
| na                      | (not answered)               | 3        | <1%          |

|       |                         |   |     |
|-------|-------------------------|---|-----|
| henna | henna                   | 2 | <1% |
| hu    | na                      | 1 | <1% |
| na    | all are equally correct | 1 | <1% |

Table 2: interspeaker variation with regards to topicalization

### 5.3. Licensing strong pronouns: copula constructions and beyond

Another set of examples where 'na is dispreferred, (31)-(32) (repeated from (22)-(23)), is unified by the fact that both of them contain a copula verb, *va* 'were' in (31), and *bli* 'become' in (32). The two examples differ in whether participants preferred *hu*, (31), or *henna*, (32). Note that example (31) is the sentence with the lowest endorsement (0.3%) of 'na.

- (31) *Viss eg va {hu<sup>56.3%</sup> / henna<sup>42.9%</sup> / na<sup>0.3%</sup>}, ville eg ... (n=378)*  
 if I were her would I  
 "If I were her, I would ..."
- (32) *Eg vil bli {henna<sup>55.2%</sup> / hu<sup>30.6%</sup> / na<sup>11.1%</sup>}. (n=359)*  
 I want become her  
 "I want to become her."

When it comes to the question of why strong pronouns are licensed (and preferred) in copula constructions, two possible explanations emerge. One possible explanation is that the complement of the copula is a prominence position, which, similar to the topicalization position in (29) disallows the weak clitic 'na. For (31), an alternative explanation holds that the complement of the copula is in fact marked for nominative (thus *hu*) rather than accusative ('na). Support for the prominence view stems from the fact that, even in (31), *henna* is endorsed by 42.9% of study participants, and *henna* is clearly an (accusative) object form. This reasoning is even more strongly supported by (32), which is also a copula construction, but exhibits the highest endorsement for *henna* in our data set. A conclusion where the choice of *hu* in (31) is due to prominence rather than nominative case is also in line with the observation that pronominal complements of copula verbs in Present Day Norwegian often occur in the accusative

case (cf. *jeg er deg* ‘I.NOM am you.ACC’ rather than *jeg er du* ‘I.NOM am you.NOM’). We thus conclude that the complement of the copula in (31)-(32) is an information structurally prominent position, rather than a position for a nominative pronoun; prominent positions require a strong pronoun (*hu* or *henna*) and do not allow for the clitic *'na*. In light of the structural similarity between the two copula constructions (31)-(32), it is an open question how the licensing conditions for *hu* and *henna* differ from one another.

## 5.4. Licensing strong pronouns: open questions

To conclude this section, we observe that the data set in this paper does not support a hypothesis where *henna* is an archaic form that is being replaced by the more innovative *hu*. Instead, the data indicate that *hu* and *henna* are both active variants in the pronominal inventory of speakers who accept all three pronominal forms (G7 in (8)g). While there are two examples in which participants converged on *hu* as the most suitable option, (29) and (31), there are also two examples in which participants converged on *henna*, namely (32), and (33). Example (33) does not involve a copula construction or topicalization of the type that we saw in Sections 5.2-5.3; its defining characteristic is the placement of *henna* in the complement position of the preposition *hos* ‘at’. It is an open question why this placement gives rise to the licensing of a strong pronoun, since we have seen that *'na* freely occurs in the complement position of prepositions (see (16), (18), and (19)).

- (33) *Eg spise hos {henna<sup>49.7%</sup> / hu<sup>27.4%</sup> / na<sup>20.2%</sup>}. (n=372)*  
 I eat at her  
 “I eat at her place.”

## 6. Conclusion

In this paper, we presented a survey of a phenomenon that has not received much attention until now, namely pronoun choice in the Nord-Jæren dialects of Norwegian. We observed that Nord-Jæren dialects have three versions of the 3<sup>rd</sup> person feminine pronoun, which appear to differ in their markedness and pronominal strength. We hypothesize that they map onto a strength scale, where the clitic

pronoun *'na* is the weak element, which contrasts with two strong variants, *hu* and *henna*. Based on overall frequency, we also conjectured that *henna* is more marked (and thus potentially stronger) than *hu*. The contribution of this data set to the existing literature is to highlight the relevance of micro-dialectal investigations for the exploration of pronominal typology. Since both *hu* and *henna* appear to be strong pronouns, their co-existence in a single dialect/language, and in individual speakers, goes against one of the initial hypotheses of Cardinaletti & Starke (1999:167), namely that there are no languages with two pronominal paradigms that are both strong, a claim that has rarely been challenged in the previous literature. This shows that the inclusion of micro-dialectal variation in research on the cross-linguistic pronominal typology is crucial for obtaining a predictive theory of *possible* pronominal typologies. Our study in particular lays the groundwork for future investigations into the pronominal paradigms of Norwegian dialects. A question for future research is how Nord-Jæren dialects compare to other dialects that have the same three forms in the accusative (without having preserved a separate dative of the type that we find in the Halså dialect).

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